

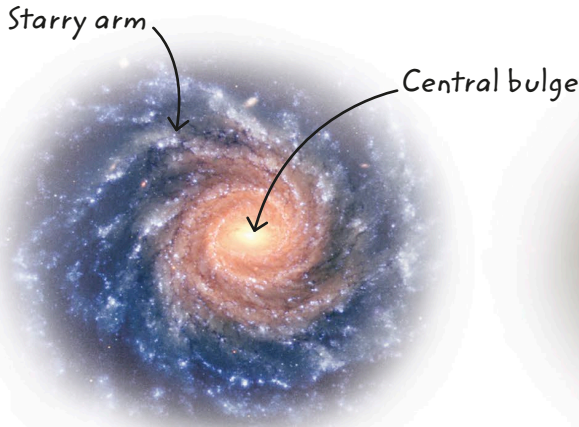
# Galaxies

Stars exist together in gigantic groups called galaxies that spin and travel through space. Each galaxy holds many billions of stars, and there are billions of galaxies in the Universe. Between galaxies, there is empty space. There are four different galaxy shapes: spiral, elliptical, barred spiral, and irregular.



## Birth of a galaxy

A galaxy starts its life as an enormous spinning cloud of gas and dust. The bigger the cloud, the bigger the galaxy. As the cloud spins, it starts to change shape and stars begin to form.



## Spirals

Spiral galaxies are in the shape of flat disks. The stars form arms that spiral out from a big bulge of stars in the center. All types of stars and nebulae can be found in spiral galaxies.

## Elliptical

Some galaxies are round like balls. Others are more like squashed balls. Some look as though they have been squashed flat. All of these are elliptical galaxies.